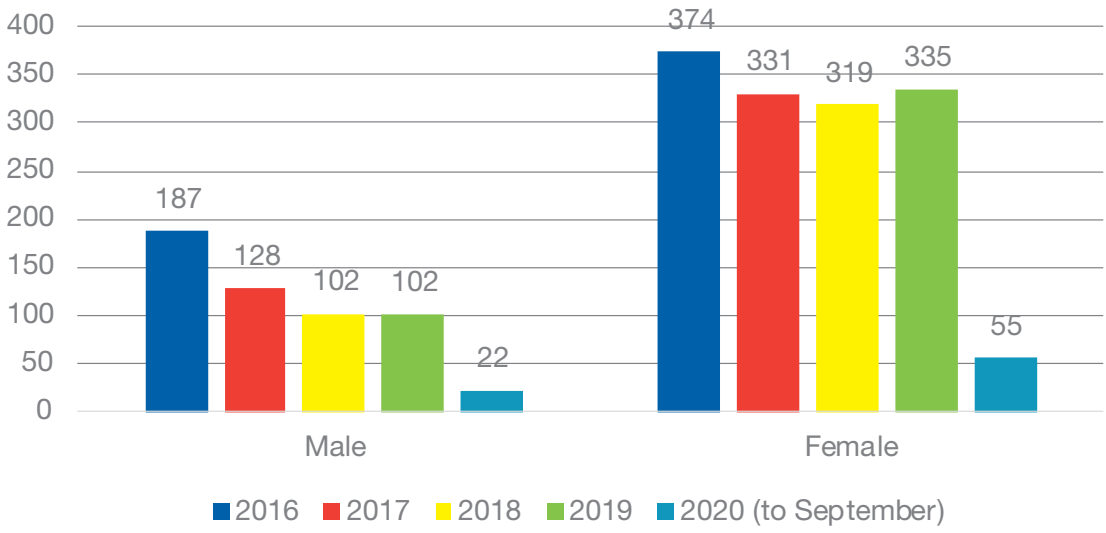
decline in 2020 in absolute numbers and as a percentage of 2019 deployment (Figure 1.9b).[9]

Figure 1.9b. Deployment of Overseas Foreign Workers by sex, new hires only (in thousands)



Source: Philippine Statistics Authority (2022)

1.5. Migrant Workers More at Risk of COVID-19 Infection

COVID-19 infection among migrants appears to be higher than among non-migrant groups (Hintermeier et al., 2020). Migrant workers are disproportionately exposed to COVID-19 because of the nature of their work and their living conditions. Many migrant workers performed essential services, including jobs in healthcare, selected manufacturing, transportation, logistics, construction, and maintenance, which continued during periods of movement restrictions (OECD, ADBI and ILO, 2021). Many migrant workers also have less access to personal protective equipment and testing and treatment facilities (OECD, ADBI and ILO, 2021). The lack of access was especially true for undocumented migrants.

Additionally, migrant workers employed in plantations far away from urban centres had limited access to information and testing. High rates of infection were also linked to overcrowded housing conditions, including shared facilities and sleeping areas, which increase the risk of transmission (ASEAN MP, 2021). Many workers in processing or assembly plants worked in conditions where physical distancing was rarely observed.

In Malaysia, out of 2,188 positive cases recorded nationwide on 25 November 2020, 1,511 were foreign workers employed by Top Glove Corporation Bhd., one of the world's largest personal protective equipment (PPE) manufacturers (*The Straits Times*, 2020; Ngui, 2020). Many other migrant workers were employed as delivery agents, public transport drivers, or restaurant waiters, and are in constant contact with the general public. Infection risk is also higher

9 Keeping in mind that for 2020 the figures are only up to October of the year.